crossing over the Sea of Japan to Korea was attempted only rarely, usually only by the most intrepid Buddhist monks and traders. The early Chinese chronicles repeatedly introduced Japan as being a land "in the middle of the ocean," emphasizing its isolation and difference from the continent. Long periods of Japanese diplomatic isolation, such as during the Heian (794–1185) or Edo (1603–1868) eras also meant that Japan was largely outside the mainstream, such as it was, of Asian historical development for centuries at a time.

The dawn of the modern world turned upside down the traditional disparity between Japan and China. Indeed, what the Chinese continue to call their "century of humiliation," from the Opium War of 1839 to 1842 to the victory of the Chinese Communist Party in 1949, was largely contemporaneous with Japan's emergence as the world's first major non-Western power. As the centuries-old Qing dynasty and China's millennia-old imperial system fell apart, Japan overthrew its seven centuries of samurai rule and "restored" the emperor to a position ostensibly leading the government. In reality, lower-level ex-samurai deposed their feudal lords and took power, centralizing the state and forging Japan into a modern nation-state that within a generation would inflict military defeats on two of the greatest empires of the day, China itself in 1895 and czarist Russia a decade later. The sidelining of civilian government control during the 1930s allowed ultranationalist military officers to invade Manchuria and fight both the United States and other European powers, resulting in devastation throughout China and Asia. During these decades, Chinese reformers overthrew the Qing dynasty, yet the new republic soon descended into decades of warlordism following the 1911 Revolution. This was followed by decades of civil war between Chiang Kai-shek's Nationalists and Mao Zedong's Communists, and then the excesses of Mao's era, even as Japan emerged from the devastation of 1945 to become the world's second-largest economy. At the end of the Cold War, few observers would have judged China to be on the cusp of an unprecedented era of growth, or have suspected that Japan would soon stumble from its lofty perch, seemingly never to return.